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The TRANSFORM Method

A practical guide to lasting change, built on systems instead of willpower

COMPLETE GUIDE 1 OF 5

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> **Disclaimer.** This educational resource presents behavioral frameworks for personal development. It does not constitute medical, psychological, psychiatric or therapeutic advice. The author is a nutrition coach, not a licensed healthcare provider. If you have a mental health condition, an eating disorder, a substance dependence or any other clinical concern, consult a qualified professional before making changes. Stopping alcohol after heavy use can be dangerous and should be done with medical guidance. Individual results vary.

BEFORE YOU READ

Start here

This is not a motivation book. If you want a speech that makes you feel unstoppable for 48 hours, there are thousands of those. This is a **working manual**. Every chapter ends with something you can do today, and the whole method fits on one page (you will find it at the end).

The idea behind it is simple. Most people who fail at changing a habit do not have a character problem. They have a **design problem**: a plan that only works on their best day, in a house, phone and social circle that were never built to help. Fix the design and the same person gets different results.

How to use this guide

- **Read it in order the first time.** The framework builds step by step.
- **Do the exercises with a pen or a notes app.** Reading without writing is the fastest way to forget everything by next week.
- **Pick ONE behavior to change.** Not three. One. You will see why in Chapter 3.
- **If you have ADHD, or you start things with energy and drop them,** this guide was written with you in mind. Everything is broken into small steps, and each step has a visible checkpoint.

Every scientific claim in this book comes from a published study or a systematic review, and the full list is at the end. Where the evidence is weaker or disputed, I tell you. Where something is my own practice and not a research finding, I say that too.

INTRODUCTION

Why I wrote this

I grew up in a very small town, with ADHD that nobody noticed. I kept starting things and kept losing them, and I explained it to myself the only way I knew: I was lazy, undisciplined, not like other people. I suffered for almost two decades in silence.

Today I have 8 years of CrossFit behind me, 4 years sober and 2 years in treatment for ADHD. None of that came from a burst of willpower. It came from small decisions, repeated in a setting I slowly learned to rebuild: what was in my house, who I spent time with, what I tracked, what I did on the day I fell off.

I also lost 38 kg of fat. I hold Precision Nutrition certifications, and I work as a nutrition coach with people who want to change how they eat, train and live. I do this because I want to help people avoid the doubts that made me suffer for so long. The pattern I see is always the same: they do not lack desire. They lack a system that survives a bad week.

> *Your life will not be perfect. But it can be a lot lighter, and it does not have to be done alone, or in silence.*

That is the reason this guide exists, and the reason it is priced so low. I wish someone had handed it to me 20 years ago.

CHAPTER 1

Why change fails, and what the research actually supports

Most resolutions fail, and that is normal

In a classic study that followed 200 people who made New Year's resolutions for two years, 77% were still keeping their pledge after one week, but only 19% after two years.[20] That means roughly four out of five resolutions did not survive. Newer research is more mixed: a one-year follow-up of 1,066 people found that 55% considered themselves successful, though that was self-reported, and the group that received support and goal-setting exercises did better than the others.[21] The consistent message across both studies is that **how you plan matters more than how much you want it.**

Another finding from the first study is worth remembering: even among the people who succeeded, more than half had at least one slip, and the average was 14 slips over two years. Slipping is part of changing, not proof you are failing.

The willpower story is shakier than you think

For years the popular explanation was ego depletion: self-control works like a muscle with a fuel tank, and every temptation you resist drains it. The idea grew out of a famous 1998 experiment by Roy Baumeister and colleagues in which people who resisted freshly baked cookies (and ate radishes) gave up sooner on an unsolvable puzzle.

The problem is what happened next. When researchers repeated the effect in large, pre-registered studies, it mostly disappeared. A 23-laboratory replication with 2,141 participants found an effect of d = 0.04, which is statistically indistinguishable from zero.[1] A later project with 36 laboratories and 3,531 participants found d = 0.06.[2] Scientists still argue about why, and a small effect may exist under some conditions, but the clean story of a finite willpower tank is not something you should build your life on.

What this means for you

Do not assume you failed because your "willpower ran out." A more useful and better supported explanation is that your plan asked too much, in the wrong place, with the wrong cues around you. That is something you can fix.

A lot of life runs on habit

In diary studies led by psychologist Wendy Wood, people reported what they were doing and thinking every hour. When they were doing something they did almost daily in a stable setting (a habit), their minds were usually on something else. When the behavior was new or the setting kept changing, their thoughts tracked what they were doing, which means it took mental effort.[3] In the first of those studies, roughly four in ten daily actions were habitual. A recent 2025 study that sampled people six times a day for a week found even higher figures for habitual starting (65%) and habitual execution (88%).[4]

The practical lesson: **a new behavior costs effort only until it becomes automatic.** The goal is to get it there as cheaply as possible.

Environment beats intention more often than we admit

Habits are tied to context. Same place, same time, same preceding action, same behavior. That is why you can quit smoking at home and light up automatically on vacation, or why a gym routine collapses when you move house. Reviews of habit research by Wood and colleagues conclude that habits are triggered by context cues and that changing the context is one of the most reliable ways to start or stop one.[5][6]

This is the core move of the TRANSFORM Method: instead of asking "how do I get more motivated?", ask "what should my environment look like so the behavior I want is the easy one?"

Who you spend time with matters, with a caveat

A well-known analysis of the Framingham Heart Study followed 12,067 people from 1971 to 2003. It found that a person's chance of becoming obese rose by 57% if a friend became obese, by 40% if an adult sibling did, and by 37% if a spouse did. It did not find the same effect among neighbors.[7] The study was observational, and other researchers argued that, with different statistical methods, the "social contagion" effect was no longer distinguishable from zero.[8] So treat it as a reason to **pay attention to your circle**, not as proof that friends make you gain weight.

CHAPTER 2

How habits form: the real numbers

Most books say "it takes 21 days to build a habit." That number has no scientific basis. The best-known study on the question was run at University College London by Phillippa Lally and colleagues. They asked 96 volunteers to pick a small behavior (an extra glass of water, a walk, a piece of fruit) and do it daily in the same context for 12 weeks, rating each day how automatic it felt.[9]

What they found	What it means
Time to reach the plateau of automaticity ranged from 18 to 254 days	There is no magic number. Simple behaviors automate faster, complex ones take much longer.
The typical (median) person needed about 66 days	Plan for two to three months, not three weeks.
Missing a single day did not materially affect the process	One slip is not a disaster. This is the scientific basis for the "never miss twice" rule in Chapter 7.
Doing the behavior more consistently fit the curve better	Consistency beats intensity. Small and regular wins.

One honest limit: this study had volunteers choosing simple behaviors, and only some of them produced a clean curve. It describes habits of that kind. A complex change (such as a whole training routine or quitting alcohol) takes a mix of habits, not one.

The cue, routine, reward loop

Researchers describe a habit as a loop: a **cue** (something in the context), a **routine** (the behavior), and a **reward** (what you get from it). Neuroscientist Ann Graybiel has reviewed how, with repetition, the brain shifts from deliberate control to automatic chunks of behavior that run from start to finish once the cue appears.[10] You do not need the neuroscience to use the idea. You only need the loop:

- To **build** a habit: attach it to a reliable cue and make the reward immediate.
- To **break** a habit: find the cue, remove or avoid it, and replace the routine with one that delivers a similar reward.

A note on dopamine

You will often read that dopamine is the "pleasure chemical" and that celebrating a win gives you a dopamine hit that wires the habit. The science is more complicated than that, and I will not claim it as proven. What I can say is that **many people stick to a behavior better when it ends with something that feels good.** That is a practical observation, not a laboratory result.

CHAPTER 3

The TRANSFORM Method at a glance

The framework has nine steps, one for each letter of the word TRANSFORM. They are cyclical, not linear: you will come back to earlier steps as your life changes.

Letter	Step	The question it answers
T	**Track** your reality	What am I actually doing, and what comes right before it?
R	**Redesign** your environment	How do I make the right action easy and the wrong action hard?
A	**Act** with minimum viable habits	What is the smallest version I can do even on a terrible day?
N	**Navigate** setbacks	What is my plan for when it goes wrong?
S	**Solidify** your identity	Who am I becoming, and how do I see the proof?

F	**Focus** on one thing	What is the ONE behavior for the next 30 days?
O	**Optimize** gradually	How do I make it a little bigger without breaking it?
R	**Repeat** daily	What does consistency look like on my worst day?
M	**Maintain** and review	How do I keep it for years, and what do I do when life changes?

Why one behavior at a time? Because Lally's data shows habits can take months to settle, and each change you start competes for the same limited attention. This is my recommendation based on that data, not a rule proven by a trial: **two or three habits that never stick are worth less than one habit that does.**

CHAPTER 4

T: Track your reality

Before you change anything, spend one week collecting data without judgment. You are not trying to be good. You are a researcher studying one subject: you.

There is good evidence that monitoring your own behavior helps, especially for eating and weight. A systematic review of weight-loss studies found a consistent association between self-monitoring and weight loss, though the authors rated the evidence as weak because of study limitations.[11] A later meta-analysis of randomized trials found that digital self-monitoring of diet and activity was linked to about 2.9 kg more weight loss than comparison conditions.[12] Tracking does not do the work for you, but it shows you what to fix.

What to write down

- **What** you did and **when**
- **Where** you were, and **who** was around
- **How you felt** before (energy 1 to 10, mood in one word)
- **What happened right before** (the trigger)

Track the **behavior**, not only the result. Weight, bank balance and race times are outcomes. They move slowly and tell you little about why. The behaviors and cues are what you can change tomorrow.

The one-week tracking template

Time	Behavior	Where / who	Mood & energy	Trigger
7:00	Snoozed alarm 3 times	Bedroom, alone	Tired, 3	Phone alarm across the room
12:30	Fast food lunch	Office, coworkers	Stressed, 6	Meeting ran long
15:00	Coffee and a pastry	Break room	Bored, 5	Afternoon slump
20:00	Streaming, no dinner prep	Couch, alone	Lonely, 3	Nothing planned
23:00	Scrolled in bed	Bedroom	Anxious, 2	Could not sleep

Use paper, a notes app, a spreadsheet, or voice memos. The best tool is the one you will actually open. If you have ADHD, **set a phone alarm three times a day** that says "log it." Do not rely on remembering.

Read your week

After seven days, look for patterns in five places: **time** (evenings?), **place** (couch? car?), **people** (alone? one specific person?), **emotion** (stress, boredom, loneliness) and **energy**. Then answer these questions in writing:

1. What am I proud of this week?
2. Which behavior do I most want to change?
3. What usually comes right before it?
4. At what time of day and in what state am I most vulnerable?
5. What behavior do I want to build instead?
6. What would make that behavior easier?

Today

Open your notes app and create the log. Write down the last three things you did and what came right before each. You have started.

CHAPTER 5

R: Redesign your environment

Now you use what you found. Environmental design has one rule: **make the behavior you want obvious and easy, and the behavior you want to stop invisible and hard.**

Add friction to what you want less of

- **Phone:** charge it outside the bedroom, turn on grayscale, remove the one or two apps that eat your day.
- **Food:** do not keep the foods you overeat at home. If you buy them, put them out of sight (opaque container, high shelf).
- **Alcohol:** remove it from your home entirely. This is covered in Chapter 14.
- **TV and streaming:** log out after each use so starting requires effort.

Remove friction from what you want more of

- **Training:** lay out clothes the night before, pack the bag, put it by the door.
- **Eating well:** prepare vegetables when you get home from the market, keep them in clear containers at eye level.
- **Reading or journaling:** leave the book on the pillow or the notebook on the desk, open.
- **Water:** fill a bottle and keep it where you work.

I call this the "seconds test." Count how many seconds stand between you and each behavior. Your goal is to make the wanted behavior a few seconds away and the unwanted one at least a minute away. This is my practical rule of thumb, not a laboratory threshold, but it matches what habit research says about context: the easiest thing in your environment tends to happen.

Design your people

1. **List the five people you spend the most time with.** For each, ask if they support or undermine the change you want.
2. **Join one community aligned with it:** a gym or CrossFit box, a running club, a sobriety group, an online course with a forum.
3. **Find one accountability partner** and schedule a weekly check-in (10 minutes is enough).
4. **Say it out loud.** Examples: "I'm not drinking anymore, please don't offer." "I'm working on my health, please don't push food on me."

Design your screen

- Unfollow accounts that make you feel behind, angry or tempted.
- Follow people who teach or inspire the identity you want.
- Turn off all notifications except calls and the messages that matter.
- Use an app blocker during focus time.

Area	Checklist item	Done
Physical	Cues for the unwanted behavior removed or hidden	[ ]
Physical	Cues for the wanted behavior visible and ready	[ ]
Social	One supportive community joined	[ ]
Social	One accountability partner chosen	[ ]
Digital	Triggering accounts unfollowed, notifications reduced	[ ]

CHAPTER 6

A: Act with minimum viable habits

The hardest part of any new behavior is the first minute. So we shrink it until it is nearly impossible to fail. I call this the **minimum viable habit**: the smallest version of the behavior that still counts.

Big goal	Minimum viable habit
Exercise 45 minutes	Put on your training shoes
Read 30 minutes	Read one page
Meditate 10 minutes	Take three slow breaths
Meal prep for the week	Cut one vegetable
Write 1,000 words	Write one sentence

Two reasons this works. First, starting is the bottleneck, and a tiny start removes the bottleneck. Second, once you have started, you often continue, and when you do not, you still kept the chain alive. Do not take my word for it: on the days it works, you will notice it yourself.

The behavior model

Stanford researcher BJ Fogg offers a simple model for thinking about this: a behavior happens when **motivation**, **ability** and a **prompt** come together at the same moment. His practical conclusion is that, since motivation fluctuates, you should make the behavior so easy that it needs very little of it.[13] It is a practical framework used widely in coaching, rather than a law of nature, but it is a very useful way to troubleshoot: when a behavior is not happening, is it missing a prompt, is it too hard, or is the motivation too low?

Habit stacking

The easiest prompt is something you already do. The formula:

> *After I [current habit], I will [tiny new habit].*

- After I pour my morning coffee, I will write one sentence in my journal.
- After I brush my teeth, I will drink a full glass of water (8 oz).
- After I turn on the shower, I will do 5 push-ups and 10 air squats while the water warms up, then step in.
- After I sit down for dinner, I will name one thing that went well.
- After I close my laptop, I will put on my training shoes.

Growing the habit

Once the tiny version feels automatic (Lally's data suggests this can take weeks to months), grow it in **small steps**: one push-up becomes three, then five, then ten. Increase only when the current level feels boring. If you skip two days after an increase, go back one step. There is no deadline.

Why the beginning feels useless

In the first weeks the visible results are small, so many people quit just before the habit takes hold. That is normal and expected. The scoreboard that matters in the beginning is **days done**, not results.

Today

Write your stack: "After I __, *I will* __ (the tiny version)." Do it once tonight.

CHAPTER 7

N: Navigate setbacks

You will miss days. The method assumes it. What separates people who keep going from people who stop is what happens in the next 24 hours.

The five-step recovery protocol

1. **Pause.** Three slow breaths. No verdict yet.
2. **Assess.** What happened? What came right before? Where, when, with whom, in what state?
3. **Learn.** Was the habit too big? The temptation too visible? Was I tired, hungry, stressed?
4. **Adjust.** Change one thing: add friction, remove friction, or write an if-then plan for this trigger.
5. **Resume.** Do the minimum version at the next opportunity. Not tomorrow. The next one.

The "never miss twice" rule

Missing once is an accident. Missing twice is the start of a new pattern. If you skip your workout, do 10 minutes of anything before bed. Lally's data supports this: a single missed day did not materially change the habit curve, so one slip is not what ruins things. The second skip, the third, and the story you tell yourself afterward are what do.

If-then planning

The most thoroughly tested tool in this book is the **implementation intention**, or if-then plan: "If [situation], then I will [specific response]." A meta-analysis of 94 tests by Peter Gollwitzer and Paschal Sheeran found a medium-to-large effect on goal achievement (d = 0.65).[14] A 2024 meta-analysis of 642 tests found effects between d = 0.27 and 0.66 depending on the outcome, with larger effects for if-then formats and for people highly motivated to reach the goal.[15] (You may have seen "success rates rise by 300%." That comes from one early study in which goals with plans were completed about three times as often. The more careful meta-analytic figure is the one to trust.)[16]

If...	Then I will...
I feel too tired to train	Do a 10-minute walk instead
I am tempted by junk food	Drink a glass of water and wait 10 minutes
I miss my morning journaling	Write three sentences before bed
I am invited to a drinking event	Bring my own non-alcoholic drink and tell one friend I'm not drinking
I feel the urge to open social media	Stand up, take three breaths, then decide

Write three if-then plans for the three situations that went wrong most often in your tracking week.

Self-compassion is not weakness

Beating yourself up after a setback feels productive. The research suggests it is not. Meta-analyses find that people who treat themselves with more self-compassion tend to practice more health-promoting behaviors (average correlation around r = .25),[17] and that multi-session self-compassion interventions improved health behavior.[18] Two honest caveats: most of this evidence is correlational, and in one of those meta-analyses self-compassion did not predict substance use.[18] Compassion is a tool for getting back on track, not a replacement for the plan.

1. **Name it:** "This is hard. I'm struggling."
2. **Normalize it:** "Everyone who changes something hard slips."
3. **Be kind:** "What would I say to a friend in this exact situation?"

The setback audit

Question	Answer
What behavior happened?	
What was the trigger?	
Time, place, people?	
Emotional state and energy (1 to 10)?	
Hungry, tired, stressed?	

What ONE change to my system prevents a repeat?

CHAPTER 8

S: Solidify your identity

James Clear, in Atomic Habits, argues that lasting change comes from changing the kind of person you believe you are, one small action at a time: every action is a vote for who you are becoming. This is a coaching idea with a lot of anecdotal support, not a proven mechanism, but it matches what many people report, and it reframes a missed day: you do not need a perfect record, just more votes for the new identity than against it.

Count the votes

- **Calendar method:** mark an X for each day you do the habit. Your only job is to not break the chain (and if you do, never twice).
- **Vote counter:** "This week I cast 6 votes for athlete and 1 against. Athlete wins."
- **Habit tracker app or printable.** Whatever you will see every day.

Celebrate immediately

BJ Fogg teaches that ending a tiny habit with a small, immediate celebration (a fist pump, a smile, a quiet "yes") helps it stick. The evidence is mostly practitioner experience rather than controlled trials, and I recommend it for a practical reason: it makes the habit feel good, and a habit that feels good is easier to repeat.

Write your identity statement

> *I am [identity]. [Identity] does [behavior]. Therefore, I [specific action].*

- I am an athlete. Athletes train consistently. Therefore I train four days a week.
- I am a reader. Readers read daily. Therefore I read ten pages every morning.
- I am sober. Sober people do not drink. Therefore I do not drink today.

CHAPTER 9

F: Focus on one thing

You now have a full toolkit, and that creates a new risk: wanting to use all of it at once. Resist it. The final four letters of TRANSFORM are about making what you built **last**, and they start with focus.

Why one

Lally's data (Chapter 2) shows that a single simple habit can take weeks to months to become automatic, and that more complex behaviors take longer. Each new change you start competes for the same limited attention in the same days. My recommendation, based on that data and on my coaching experience, is simple: **one identity, one tiny habit, thirty days.** Anything else goes on a "later" list.

How to choose your ONE

1. Look at your tracking week (Chapter 4). Which behavior, if it changed, would make the rest easier? Often it is sleep, a morning routine or an evening trigger.
2. Pick the one you are most willing to do on a bad day, not the one that sounds most impressive.
3. Write it as a tiny version (Chapter 6) and attach it to a cue.

Month	ONE habit	Stacked on
1	A glass of water after brushing teeth	The morning routine you already have
2	Five push-ups and ten air squats when the shower starts	The water habit
3	Three sentences of journaling	The coffee
4	One page of reading in bed	Putting the phone on the charger

In four months you would have four stacked habits instead of four abandoned attempts.

Today

Write your ONE on a sticky note. Put it where you will see it tomorrow morning.

CHAPTER 10

O: Optimize gradually

Once your tiny habit feels automatic, you can grow it. This is where most people go wrong in the opposite direction: they feel good after a week and jump from one push-up to a full routine.

The boredom rule

Grow only when the current level feels boring. If it still takes some effort, stay there. If you grow and skip two days in a row, go back one step. There is no deadline.

Level	Push-up habit	Reading habit	Water habit
1	1 push-up	1 page	A few sips
2	3 push-ups	1 page, then 5 minutes	A small glass
3	5 push-ups	10 minutes	A full glass (8 oz)
4	10 push-ups	20 minutes	A glass plus the bottle goes with you
5	A full session	A chapter	Target for the day set

Optimize the system, not only the habit

Growth is not only "more." You can also improve the **cue** (make it more reliable), the **environment** (remove one more bit of friction) or the **reward** (make it feel better). If a habit keeps breaking, optimizing the cue is usually smarter than adding effort.

Today

Look at your ONE habit. Is it boring yet? If yes, write the next level. If not, write what would make it easier.

CHAPTER 11

R: Repeat daily

Consistency beats intensity. In Lally's study, people who did the behavior more consistently produced a cleaner habit curve, and missing a single day did not materially change the process.[9]

The minimum version

Every habit needs a floor, the smallest version you will do even on your worst day. Ten push-ups daily for two months builds a habit. Two big sessions a week usually do not, even if the total volume is higher, because the cue and context are not repeated daily. Show up with the floor rather than skipping.

Plan your hard days in advance

Hard day	Your floor
Travel	Same cue, smallest version, in the hotel room
Sick	Three slow breaths, drink water, log it
Exhausted	Put on the shoes, then decide
Overwhelmed	One sentence in the journal, nothing more
Social event	Do it before you leave, or the next morning

Write your own floors before you need them. On a bad day your brain will not invent a good plan, and that is exactly when the pre-written one saves you.

Today

Write your floor for your ONE habit, and your floor for a travel day.

CHAPTER 12

M: Maintain for the long term

Starting is not the hard part. **Keeping it** is. In the resolution study from Chapter 1, even the people who succeeded slipped about 14 times over two years.[20] Maintenance is mostly a skill of coming back.

The quarterly review

Every three months, put 30 minutes on the calendar and answer:

1. Which habits are automatic now?
2. Which still take effort, and why?
3. What changed in my life (job, home, relationships, training) that affects the system?
4. What should I keep, adjust or retire?
5. What identity do I want to build next?

Plan for life changes

Most habits break when the context changes: a move, a new job, a breakup, an injury, a baby, a new training block. Before the change, if you can, write: "If my context changes, then I will rebuild my cue on day one." After the change, treat it like a new tracking week: look at what is actually happening and redesign.

Keep a relapse-prevention note

Prompt	Your answer
My early warning signs (sleep, mood, skipped days)	
The first thing I do when I see them	
The person I will tell	
The floor I return to	

Today

Put a quarterly review on your calendar, three months from today.

CHAPTER 13

Using the method: body and nutrition

Here is how the framework looks for someone who wants to improve body composition and eating.

Step	Example
Track (week 1)	Log meals, hunger, mood and context. Notice emotional eating triggers and the time of day when choices get worse.
Redesign (week 2)	Take trigger foods out of sight, pre-cut vegetables in clear containers, lay out training clothes, join a training community or find a training partner.
Act (week 3 on)	Tiny habit 1: add one vegetable or protein source to each meal. Tiny habit 2: a 10-minute walk after dinner.
Navigate	If I overeat at a meal, then the next meal is normal. No punishment, no skipping meals.
Solidify	"I'm someone who feeds my body well." Mark each day you hit the minimum.
F, O, R, M	Focus on the first habit for 30 days (F). Grow it gradually (O). Repeat daily, even in the minimum version (R). Review every three months (M).

This guide teaches the behavior side of change. For specifics on what to eat, see Guide 2 (Nutrition Fundamentals) in this collection.

CHAPTER 14

Using the method: sobriety and recovery

This is the area I know best from my own life, and the one that needs the most care.

Safety first

If you drink heavily or daily, **stopping suddenly can cause dangerous withdrawal** (including seizures). Talk to a doctor before you quit. This guide is a behavioral companion to professional care, not a replacement for it.

Step	Example
Track (week 1)	Log when cravings hit, how strong they are (1 to 10), where you were, who with, and how you felt. Notice the pattern.
Redesign (week 2)	Remove alcohol from home. Plan routes that avoid bars. Delete delivery apps. Tell the people closest to you.
Act	Tiny habit: when a craving hits, drink a glass of water, take 10 slow breaths and text one person before deciding anything. Attend one support meeting a week.
Navigate	If-then plans for parties, bad days and anniversaries. If I slip, then I tell my person the same day and resume the next hour.
Solidify	"I am sober today." Count the days where you can see them.
F, O, R, M	Focus on one day at a time (F). Rebuild one area at a time (O). Repeat the daily check-in (R). Review every three months with someone who knows you (M).

On support groups: a 2020 Cochrane review of 27 studies and 10,565 participants found that manualized Alcoholics Anonymous / twelve-step facilitation programs increased continuous abstinence at 12 months compared with other established treatments such as cognitive behavioral therapy (risk ratio 1.21), and performed at least as well on other drinking outcomes.[19] They are not for everyone, and alternatives exist, but peer support is one of the best-supported tools available and it is free.

CHAPTER 15

Using the method: other areas of life

The same nine steps work for money, sleep, work and relationships. The logic does not change: track what actually happens, redesign the environment, shrink the habit, plan for setbacks, count your votes. For example, for money: track every expense for a week, set up an automatic transfer

on payday, review spending for two minutes each night, and write an if-then plan for impulse purchases ("if I want to buy something unplanned, then I wait 48 hours"). The 48-hour rule is a common practitioner rule, not a researched number. Pick the version that fits you.

CHAPTER 16

Your first 30 days

Week	Focus	Your checkpoint
1	Track. Pick your ONE behavior. Log it three times a day.	Seven days of notes
2	Redesign: change two things at home and one on your phone. Find a person or a group.	Environment list done
3	Act: start the tiny version after a stable cue. Celebrate it.	Mark every day
4	Navigate: write three if-then plans. Review your week with the audit.	One adjustment made

Your only target in these 30 days: **not breaking the chain twice in a row.** Everything else is a bonus.

CHAPTER 17

Beliefs: the part most plans skip

So far everything has been about behavior and environment. There is a third layer that decides whether you even start: what you **believe** is possible, and what you believe your effort is doing. Nir Eyal's book Beyond Belief builds on this idea, and Ellen Langer's The Mindful Body explores it from the angle of health. I am summarizing them here and tying them to published studies; both are popular books, not research papers, so I will flag which parts have study support and which are the authors' interpretation.

Beliefs as tools, not truths

Eyal's central argument is that a belief is not just a description of the world, it is a tool that shapes where you look, what you expect to feel and whether you act. He suggests asking of a belief not only "is it true?" but "is it **useful**?" That is a sensible lens for habit change: "I'm just not

a disciplined person" may feel true, but it is useless, because it points to nothing you can do. "I need a smaller first step" may be less flattering, but it is something you can act on.

He also stresses that belief does not replace action. A belief is something that makes your effort more likely, not something that does the work for you. I agree with that completely, and it is the reason this chapter sits at the back of the book, after the tools.

What the studies show

Study	What was done	What it suggests	Limits
Crum & Langer, 2007[22]	84 hotel room attendants in 7 hotels. Half were told that their daily work counts as good exercise, with examples. The other half were told nothing.	Four weeks later the informed group believed they exercised more, and showed lower weight, blood pressure, body fat and BMI, although their actual behavior had not changed.	One small study with short follow-up. I did not find a large independent replication, so treat it as suggestive.
Levy et al., 2002[23]	660 adults aged 50+ were followed for up to 23 years.	Those with more positive views of aging lived 7.5 years longer on average, even after adjusting for age, sex, socioeconomic status, loneliness and health.	Observational, so it cannot prove cause. The authors found it was partly explained by will to live.

Notice what both studies have in common: they do not claim that thinking positive thoughts cures anything. They suggest that how people **interpret** what they are doing, and what they expect from the future, can go along with measurable differences. That is a reason to take your own beliefs seriously, not a promise that belief alone changes your body.

Three beliefs worth checking

1. **"I always quit."** Check the evidence: what have you stuck with for at least a month? List it. (Training, a job, a relationship, an old habit.) You have a track record, even if it does not feel that way.
2. **"One bad day ruins everything."** The habit research in Chapter 2 says otherwise: missing a single day did not materially change how habits formed.
3. **"Small steps do not count."** On this one the science is plain. The people in Lally's study built automaticity through small, repeated actions in a stable context.

Exercise: the belief audit

Step	Write down
1. The belief	The sentence you tell yourself ("I can't stay consistent.")
2. The evidence for it	Facts only, not feelings
3. The evidence against it	At least two real examples from your life
4. Useful or not?	Does it help you act? If not, write a replacement that is honest and usable ("I stay consistent when the step is small.")
5. The test	Pick a one-week experiment. Log one line of evidence each night.

CHAPTER 18

Energy: your brain is part of your body

Psychiatrist Christopher Palmer, in Brain Energy, proposes that many mental health conditions may be understood as problems of metabolism in brain cells, especially in the mitochondria that produce energy, and that this could link biology, psychology and social stress in one framework. This is an **emerging hypothesis**, not an established consensus, and I have only seen it described in public summaries, not tested it myself. I mention it because it points toward something worth taking seriously, regardless of how the debate turns out: **sleep, movement and food are not extras. They are part of the machinery that makes habits possible.**

Movement is not just for the body

A 2024 systematic review and network meta-analysis in the BMJ pooled 218 randomized trials with 14,170 participants and found that exercise reduced depressive symptoms compared with usual care or placebo conditions: walking or jogging (g = -0.62), yoga (g = -0.55) and strength training (g = -0.49) all showed moderate effects, and more intense exercise did better.[24] The authors suggest exercise could be considered alongside therapy and medication. They also state the confidence in the evidence is low to very low, because few trials were well blinded.

I want to be careful here: exercise is not a substitute for professional care if you have depression, and **you should never stop prescribed medication without your doctor.** What this research does tell us is that training, which many of you already do, is also a mood and energy tool, and that you can use it deliberately.

The basics that make everything else easier

Basic	Why it matters for habits	Where to go deeper
Sleep	When you are exhausted, every habit costs more. Protecting sleep is protecting your system.	Guide 5: Sleep, Recovery and Mental Resilience
Food	Regular, adequate meals keep energy steady and decisions easier.	Guide 2: Nutrition Fundamentals
Movement	Training builds the identity and improves mood.	Chapter 6 (start tiny)
Environment	The right cues remove the need for effort.	Guide 3: Environment Design
Emotions	Stress and loneliness are the strongest triggers I see.	Guide 4: Emotional Intelligence

A note on diet and mental health

Some people are exploring specific diets for psychiatric conditions. This is an early area of research, and any change like that should be supervised by a physician. Nothing in this guide is a treatment for a mental health condition.

CHAPTER 19

If you have ADHD (or think you might)

I have ADHD, and I was diagnosed late. Most habit advice assumes a brain that remembers things, tolerates boredom and plans ahead. If that is not your brain, the standard advice can feel like another way to fail. This chapter explains what I have found helpful, and where the research stands.

What the research says

- A meta-analysis of 28 experimental studies found that if-then planning had a large effect on goal achievement in people with mental health problems (d = 0.99), across different conditions and goals.[25] This is not an ADHD-specific result, so treat it as encouraging, not proof.

- A 2026 meta-analysis in children found a small-to-medium benefit from if-then plans (g = 0.31), and in some analyses larger effects in children with ADHD, which the authors read as plans being most helpful when self-regulation is limited.[26] Adult ADHD evidence is thinner, so I would call this promising, not settled.

What has worked for me and my clients (practice, not research)

- **Put it outside your head.** Alarms, sticky notes, objects placed in your path. If a plan depends on remembering, it will fail.
- **Make progress visible.** A paper calendar on the wall or a tracker you see daily. Out of sight is out of mind, in both directions.
- **Shrink the step further.** If the tiny habit still feels heavy, make it smaller. "Open the book" counts.
- **Use a body double.** Doing the habit at the same time as a friend (in person or on a call) often makes starting easier.
- **Rotate the reward, not the habit.** Boredom is a real risk. Keep the habit but change the small reward every few weeks.
- **Plan your restart.** Write your if-then for what you do after a missed day, before you miss it.
- **Treat treatment as part of the system.** If you are being treated, medication and therapy are part of your toolkit. Talk to your doctor about what to track.

Speak to a professional

If you suspect you have ADHD, the way to know is a proper evaluation by a qualified clinician, not a checklist or a book.

CHAPTER 20

Troubleshooting

What is happening	What to try
I forget to do it	The cue is too weak. Pair it with something you never skip, and add a visible object or an alarm.
I do it but it feels pointless	Track days done, not results. Results lag by weeks.

I was doing great and then travel broke it	Habits are tied to context. Write a travel version: same cue, smaller step, and an if-then for the first morning back.
I miss, then give up for days	Use the "never miss twice" rule. Set the minimum version at a ridiculous size and do it today.
I get bored	Keep the cue and routine, change the reward or the setting. Add a new small challenge only after the habit is automatic.
I keep starting new habits	Return to Chapter 9. One behavior for 30 days. Write the others on a "later" list.
Someone around me undermines it	Say the sentence out loud ("please do not offer me that"), and increase time with people who support the goal.

CHAPTER 21

Pick your case: starter plans

Not sure where to start? Find the situation closest to yours. Each plan gives you the whole nine-letter path in a few lines. It is a starting point, and you can change any of it after your first tracking week.

If this is you…	Your starter plan
I want to lose body fat and keep it off	**T:** log meals, hunger and mood for 7 days. **R:** remove trigger foods from sight, pre-cut vegetables at eye level. **A:** add one vegetable or protein source to one meal. **N:** "If I overeat, the next meal is normal." **S:** "I feed my body well." **F/O/R/M:** one meal for 30 days, then a second, review at 3 months. Details in Guide 2.
I want to stop drinking	**Talk to a doctor first if you drink heavily. T:** log cravings and triggers. **R:** no alcohol at home, new routes, tell one person. **A:** at a craving, glass of water, 10 breaths, text one person. **N:** write your if-then plans for parties and bad days. **S:** "I am sober today." **M:** one-day-at-a-time check-ins, a support group if it fits you.
I start strong and quit after two weeks	**T:** note the day you usually drop and what happened the day before. **R:** shrink to a 2-minute habit. **A:** stack it on a fixed cue. **N:** "Never miss twice" plus a pre-written restart. **F:** only ONE habit for 30 days. **R:** the floor version on bad days.

I have ADHD and feel overwhelmed by plans	Read Chapter 19. **R:** put everything outside your head: alarms, objects, a wall calendar. **A:** pick the smallest step you can think of, then make it smaller. **N:** write your restart plan today. **F:** one habit, nothing else.
I train but my eating and sleep are a mess	**T:** one week of sleep time, meals and training. **R:** fix sleep first (phone out of the bedroom). **A:** one fixed meal per day. **S:** "I am an athlete, and athletes recover." Guides 2 and 5 go deeper.
I feel stuck, and nothing has worked	**T:** write what you have actually stuck with for a month. **Audit your belief** (Chapter 17). **F:** pick the easiest of your goals, not the biggest. **A:** two minutes. **S:** count the votes for a week. Consider a free call to look at it together.

Whichever you choose, finish by filling in the one-page plan in the Appendix. A plan on paper is far more likely to be used than one in your head.

CONCLUSION

The TRANSFORM Method on one page

1. **Track** one week, without judgment.
2. **Redesign** your environment so the right action is the easy one.
3. **Act** with the smallest version of the habit, after a stable cue.
4. **Navigate** setbacks with the five-step protocol and if-then plans. Never miss twice.
5. **Solidify** your identity: count your votes and celebrate.
6. **Focus** on ONE habit for 30 days.
7. **Optimize** in small steps, only when the current level is boring.
8. **Repeat** daily, with the minimum version on bad days.
9. **Maintain** with a quarterly review and a plan for life changes.

You are not broken, and you did not fail for lack of character. You were running a plan that was not built for your real life. Now you know how to build one that is.

APPENDIX

Worksheets

Your TRANSFORM plan on one page

Letter	Your answer
T Track: what I will log for 7 days	
R Redesign: two changes in my environment	
A Act: my tiny habit (2 minutes or less) and its cue	
N Navigate: my if-then plan and restart	
S Solidify: my identity statement	
F Focus: my ONE habit for 30 days	
O Optimize: the next level, and when	
R Repeat: my floor for a bad day	
M Maintain: my review date	

1. Your ONE behavior

Prompt	Your answer
Identity I am building	
The tiny version (2 minutes or less)	
After I... (cue)	
Where, exactly	
How I will celebrate	
If-then plan for the hardest situation	

2. Weekly review (every Sunday, 10 minutes)

Question	Answer
Days I did the minimum (out of 7)	
What helped?	
What got in the way?	
One change for next week	
One thing I am proud of	

3. The 30-day chain

Fill one box per day. Do not break the chain twice.

1 [ ]	2 [ ]	3 [ ]	4 [ ]	5 [ ]	6 [ ]
7 [ ]	8 [ ]	9 [ ]	10 [ ]	11 [ ]	12 [ ]
13 [ ]	14 [ ]	15 [ ]	16 [ ]	17 [ ]	18 [ ]
19 [ ]	20 [ ]	21 [ ]	22 [ ]	23 [ ]	24 [ ]
25 [ ]	26 [ ]	27 [ ]	28 [ ]	29 [ ]	30 [ ]

About the author

Adriano Monteiro is a nutrition coach with Precision Nutrition certifications. He has lost 38 kg of fat, has competed in CrossFit for 8 years, has been sober for 4 years and has been in treatment for ADHD for 2 years. He writes and coaches for people who want lasting change without having to suffer in silence, and works with clients in English from Brazil.

Want help applying this to YOUR life?

Book a free 20-minute call. We will pick your ONE behavior, look at your first week of tracking and build your first stack together. No pressure, no sales pitch, just a plan.

Book your free 20-minute call

https://calendly.com/adriano-nutrition/free-20-min-discovery-call

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